PERSONAL BRANDING THROUGH CONSUMER BEHAVIOR

Hrithika Patalay

Consumer Behavior - MKT-5692 - LMMKT1
Master's in International Marketing
Hult International Business School

Crafting "Insight Alchemist" for Luxury Agency Recruitment

Introduction: Personal Branding as a Consumer Behaviour Challenge

This paper adopts a reflexive self-analysis rather than empirical data collection to examine my personal branding within the competitive graduate recruitment marketplace for brand strategist roles in creative agencies and luxury marketing. Here, I function as a personal brand vying for attention, trust and selection through perception, signalling and memory associations, where recruiters prioritise symbolic cues alongside qualifications. Consumer-based brand equity theory posits that brands endure as strong, favourable and unique mental associations, suggesting my personal brand similarly succeeds by activating resonant networks in evaluators' minds. Applying consumer behaviour principles to myself, this analysis treats me—a detail-oriented thinker targeting global, travel-intensive luxury roles in agencies valuing creativity, wellbeing and growth—as a reflective case study marked by versatile creative problem-solving, critical thinking and playfully passionate strategic expression. The objective is to craft and justify an authentic behavioural label that counters misunderstandings arising from subtle signals, aligning my internal identity (highly creative, intelligent, adaptive and competitive) with external perceptions in high-speed evaluation settings. The structure proceeds by mapping core identity, defining target audiences, presenting the label, offering theoretical rationale, and detailing go-to-market applications across CVs, LinkedIn and interviews.

Theoretical Foundations for Crafting a Personal Brand

2.1 Consumer Identity, Self-Concept, and Authenticity

Drawing on consumer identity and self-concept clarity research, identity mapping structures my introspection around core values, strengths and personality, paralleling how marketers define a brand’s central meaning prior to external positioning. My analysis commences with non-negotiables—creative challenge, impact, autonomy and continuous learning—which serve as internal decision rules for project selection, revealing an orientation toward growth, originality and client-facing value creation

2.2 Brands, Memory Structures, and Meaning Creation

Consumer-based brand equity theory posits that brands endure as strong, favourable and unique mental associations, suggesting my personal brand similarly succeeds by activating resonant networks in evaluators' minds. Lived behavioural patterns and prior feedback highlight my propensity to spot patterns others miss, pose sharp questions and transform potential into impactful opportunities through insight synthesis and deck storytelling, constructing a self-concept centred on intellectual edge and elevated team thinking.

2.3 Behavioural Labelling and Identity Signalling

This process frames strengths like connecting disparate ideas and making analytically bold contributions as functional and symbolic brand benefits, while my observer-first interaction style—incisive yet situationally adaptive—is interpreted through brand personality dimensions.

2.4 Avoiding Egocentric Bias in Personal Brand Construction

Common misperceptions, such as quietness read as disengagement or competitiveness as aggression/self-centredness, emerge as key data informing perceptual gaps between my intended signals and external reception. Thus, qualitative introspection proves not subjective but a rigorous, theory-driven method for articulating internal identity claims before crafting an externally resonant label and deployment strategy.

Applying Identity Mapping as a Reflexive Analytical Approach

This paper applies identity mapping as a reflexive analytical framework to examine myself as a personal brand, following Ingram (2025) in structuring self-analysis around core values, strengths, capabilities and personality traits. Rather than empirical data collection, this qualitative method leverages introspection, prior feedback and behavioural patterns to specify internal identity claims, mirroring how marketers articulate a brand's central meaning before external positioning. Core values—creative challenge, impact, autonomy and continuous learning—emerge as decision rules guiding project engagement, while strengths like insight synthesis, pattern-spotting and deck storytelling reveal functional benefits such as elevating team thinking and client outcomes.

The approach justifies self-reflection as legitimate by treating common misperceptions (quietness as disengagement, competitiveness as threat) as diagnostic data points, identifying perceptual gaps between intended signals and reception. This lens functions to ground claims in observable patterns—observer-first contributions that trigger defensiveness despite respectful intent—ensuring analysis remains systematic rather than anecdotal. By foregrounding these elements, identity mapping provides the evidentiary basis for subsequent label development, bridging self-concept clarity with recruiter heuristics in a theory-informed manner that validates reflexive inquiry as rigorous consumer behaviour application.

Personal Identity Analysis and Target Audience Definition

4.1 Core Values, Strengths, and Personal Brand Personality

My core values—creative challenge, impact, autonomy and continuous learning—form an internal compass directing engagement toward projects with growth potential and client-facing originality, aligning with self-concept clarity in consumer identity theory. Strengths manifest as insight synthesis, connecting disparate ideas into impactful deck narratives, and pattern-spotting that elevates team discourse, delivering functional benefits like strategic elevation alongside symbolic intellectual edge. Personal brand personality emerges as observer-first yet incisive, analytically bold and adaptively competitive, where respectful contributions intended to refine outcomes risk misperception as controlling threats, underscoring the need for calibrated external signalling.

4.2 Target Audience Segmentation and Perceptual Expectations

Primary target audiences comprise hiring managers in creative agencies pursuing luxury brand strategy roles, prioritising portfolios that signal immediate creativity and team fit amid high-volume screening. Secondary audiences include professional peers and mentors in global networks valuing travel-intensive, wellbeing-focused environments. These evaluators operate under heuristic constraints, scanning for extroverted buzzwords and unambiguous proof, where my subtle signals—detail-oriented depth over overt performance—clash with expectations of unthreatening collaboration, heightening risks of defensive filtering absent clear behavioural labelling.

4.3 Core Consumer Behaviour Problem: Perceptual Misalignment in Signal Reception

The central consumer behaviour challenge in this personal branding analysis lies in a perceptual misalignment between my internally coherent, strategically incisive identity and the external interpretations formed by recruiters and peers under cognitive constraints typical of graduate recruitment. In creative agency contexts, where portfolios serve as primary signals amid high applicant volumes, my observer-first style—characterised by pattern-spotting, sharp questioning and idea synthesis—often triggers defensive reactions rather than recognition of value addition. Specifically, contributions intended to elevate outcomes are misinterpreted as controlling or threatening, with even kind, respectful delivery read as inauthentic due to others' insecurities, positioning me as a team risk rather than an intellectual edge.

This issue exemplifies egocentric bias in perception formation, where I have reflexively assumed evaluators would intuitively grasp my strategic depth without overt behavioural labelling, leading to assumptions that "telling them what they expect" or letting work speak suffices. However, insider self-perceptions like "playfully passionate" fail to land clearly, fostering frustration and a risk of dismissing others as unperceptive, which further entrenches isolation in fast-heuristic environments scanning for extroverted buzzword alignment over quiet credibility. On a 1–10 scale, the likelihood of my profile being filtered as "generic" or "disruptive" absent a clear label rate at 9, as recruiters prioritise unambiguous proof and consistency amid information overloads. Addressing this through behavioural labelling becomes essential to recalibrate associations, ensuring my detail-oriented, adaptive competitiveness activates favourable recruiter memory structures rather than defensive heuristics.

Crafting the Positive Personal Brand Label

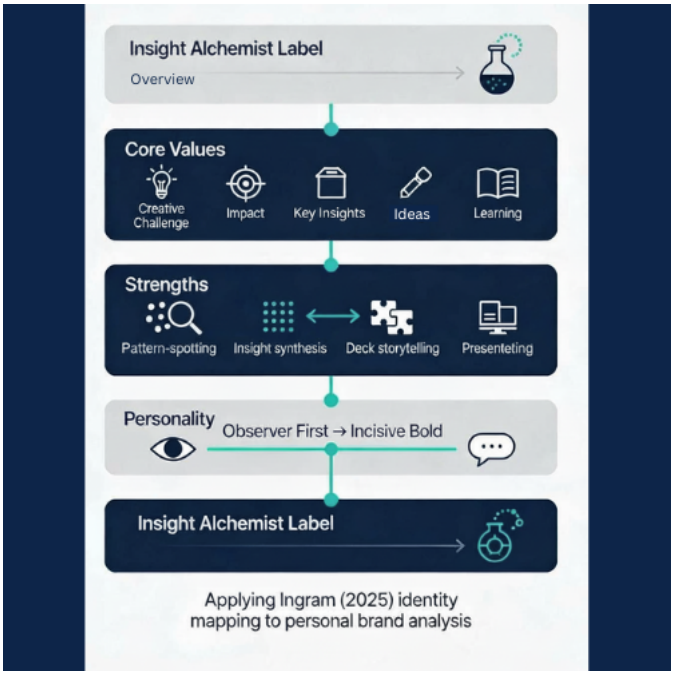
5.1 Design Principles for an Effective Positive Label

Behavioural labelling theory, as articulated by Fritze et al. (2024), posits that concise labels function as identity cues and behavioural prompts, shaping self-perception and guiding actions in alignment with desired outcomes. Rather than merely describing functional roles, an effective label signals how I think, behave and add value, activating resonant associations in evaluators' minds while countering perceptual misalignments like those identified earlier—defensiveness toward incisive contributions or quietness read as disengagement. Drawing on this framework, the label must be short and distinctive to penetrate heuristic screening in luxury agency recruitment, non-generic to differentiate from buzzword-heavy profiles, behaviourally activating to prompt bolder yet authentic signalling, and future-oriented to evoke adaptability for global, travel-intensive roles. My design prioritises "Insight Alchemist" and "Pattern Igniter" as candidates, each prompting synthesis of unseen details into impactful luxury experiences without performative extroversion, ensuring internal authenticity aligns with external impact in high-stakes contexts.

5.2 The Personal Brand Label and Supporting Tagline

The selected personal brand label—"Insight Alchemist"—encapsulates my core as a detail-oriented strategist who transforms overlooked patterns into creative, client-elevating solutions, supported by the tagline: "Activating insight-driven patterns to shape luxury perception." This formulation unpacks as behaviourally activating it cues me toward bolder signalling of intellectual edge—spotting connections others miss and crafting deck narratives—without diluting observer-first authenticity, rating 8/10 in motivational resonance for embodying it across CVs and interviews. Distinctive from generic "innovative thinker," it evokes an alchemical process of value creation, triggering recruiter associations of out-of-box

impact over threat, futureproofing for agencies valuing strategic creativity in global luxury spaces. Non-generic by rooting passion in demonstrable work rather than words, the label bridges self-concept clarity with perceptual expectations, prompting favourable memory structures amid portfolio-driven evaluations.



Strategic Rationale and Personal Brand Implications

6.1 Alignment with Personal Identity and Career Aspirations

"Insight Alchemist" demonstrates tight coherence with my identity map through identity congruence theory, where internal self-concept aligns seamlessly with external expression to foster authenticity and behavioural consistency. This label mirrors core values of creative challenge, impact and autonomy, as evidenced by my 2019 undergraduate initiative "Feel the K-pop"—spotting nascent Korean cultural patterns ahead of local trends, securing sponsorships from the state cultural department and Korean Consulate, and transforming a sub-event into a pioneering college representation. Such pattern recognition and alchemical value creation exemplify insight synthesis strengths, while its strategic observer-first deployment—adapting to situational responses without performative loudness—aligns with incisive, analytically bold personality, ensuring the label supports career aspirations in global, travel-intensive luxury agency roles.

6.2 Resonance with Target Audiences and Brand Associations

For luxury agency recruiters scanning portfolios under heuristic pressure, "Insight Alchemist" activates Keller et al.'s (2020) associative networks, triggering mental shortcuts from "strategic innovator" to "client impact generator" and "master persuader right for the job." Unlike vague descriptors, it instantly signals A-class talent capable of quiet, intentional creativity—elevating deck narratives and unseen connections into luxury perception-shaping outcomes—amid 30-second evaluations favouring proof over hype.

6.3 Managing Bias, Risks, and Alternative Positionings

Applying Herzog et al. (2021), the label deliberately sidesteps egocentric projections like assuming recruiters grasp nuanced self-views, instead prioritising perspective-taking:

maintaining calm sensibility while providing unambiguous team-fit proof beyond insider passion claims, mitigating risks of defensiveness or filtering as disruptive.

6.4 Activating the Label Across Professional Touchpoints

Distinct from "Passionate Marketer" or extroverted "Creative Disruptor" buzz, "Insight Alchemist" is not loud or performative but intentional, signalling quiet credibility over inflated hype; it activates across CV headlines, LinkedIn narratives and interviews as a consistent cue for agencies seeking adaptive strategists in global luxury impact.

Go-to-Market Strategy: Applying the Label

The "Insight Alchemist" label operationalises across professional touchpoints through consistent repetition and signal reinforcement, ensuring memory network activation in line with Keller et al. (2020) principles. On the CV, experiences reframed through this lens—such as "Insight Alchemist: Spotted nascent trends, alchemised sponsorships into pioneering event" for the 2019 Feel the K-pop initiative—position achievements as alchemical value creation, elevating pattern-spotting into tangible impact.

LinkedIn deploys it as the headline "Insight Alchemist | Transforming Patterns into Luxury Impact," with the About section opener mirroring the elevator pitch: "As an Insight Alchemist, I observe subtle patterns, synthesise meaning, and translate them into refined, strategic impact." Content tone emphasises "unseen connections" in luxury cases, sharing pattern analyses and strategic opinions to build associative proof.

In interviews, storytelling structures responses around the label—"As an Insight Alchemist, I first observe patterns, then synthesise into impact"—providing a consistent narrative arc from observation to outcome. Networking introduces with "I'm the Insight Alchemist who connects dots others miss," reinforcing cues across events for heuristic familiarity.

Anticipated consequences include increased callbacks from luxury agencies and recruiter curiosity about my work, fostering opportunities in travel-intensive roles. Risks of appearing overly niche (e.g., FMCG applicability) are mitigated by the label's adaptive depth, while the alternative "Pattern Igniter" lacks alchemical refinement—Insight Alchemist prevails by embodying information synthesis for originality, ensuring broad strategic resonance without dilution.

Reflection and Conclusion

This reflexive journey through identity mapping, perceptual misalignment and label crafting has illuminated the strategic depth required to align my observer-first, incisive essence with luxury agency expectations, transforming potential defensiveness into recognised intellectual edge. Personally, embodying "Insight Alchemist" fosters bolder yet authentic signalling, as seen in reframing past initiatives like Feel the K-pop, while strategically reinforcing consistency across touchpoints builds long-term associative networks for global career trajectories.

The process underscores meta-awareness: avoiding egocentric assumptions through Herzog-inspired perspective-taking ensures the label resonates beyond self-view, mitigating risks in heuristic-driven recruitment. Looking ahead, this behavioural cue orients toward sustained impact in travel-intensive roles, evolving with experiential refinement.

Ultimately, personal branding emerges not as self-promotion but as deliberate meaning management—shaping memory structures to activate value in others' minds.

References

- Fritze, M P, Volckner, F & Melnyk, F, (2024), “Behavioral Labeling: Prompting Consumer Behavior Through Activity Tags,” Journal of Marketing, 88, 4, 22 - 39.
- Herzog, W., Hattula, J. D., & Dahl, D. W. (2021). Marketers project their personal preferences onto consumers: overcoming the threat of egocentric decision making. Journal of Marketing Research, 58(3), 456–475.
- Ingram, P, (2025), “Who are you as a leader?’ Harvard Business Review, March-April, 92 - 101.
- Keller, K. L., Inman, J. J., Campbell, M. C., Kirmani, A., & Price, L. L. (2020). Consumer research insights on brands and branding: a jcr curation. Journal of Consumer Research, 46(5), 995–1001.
- Kim, C. K., Han, D., & Park, S. B. (2001). The effect of brand personality and brand identification on brand loyalty: Applying the theory of social identification. Japanese Psychological Research, 43(4), 195–206. (Cited via later summaries on brand personality and self-identity.)
- Perplexity AI. (2025). Perplexity AI [Large language model].
- Rindfleisch, A., Burroughs, J. E., Wong, N., & Netemeyer, R. G. (2014). Self-concept clarity: Exploring its role in consumer behavior. Journal of Consumer Psychology, 24(1), 22–39.
- Wright, K. (2011). Deconstructing signaling theory: A test of the unique and joint effects of recruitment-related information on applicant attraction (Master’s thesis). University of Wisconsin–Stout